

Childcare Costs Hit Hardest in the Early Years

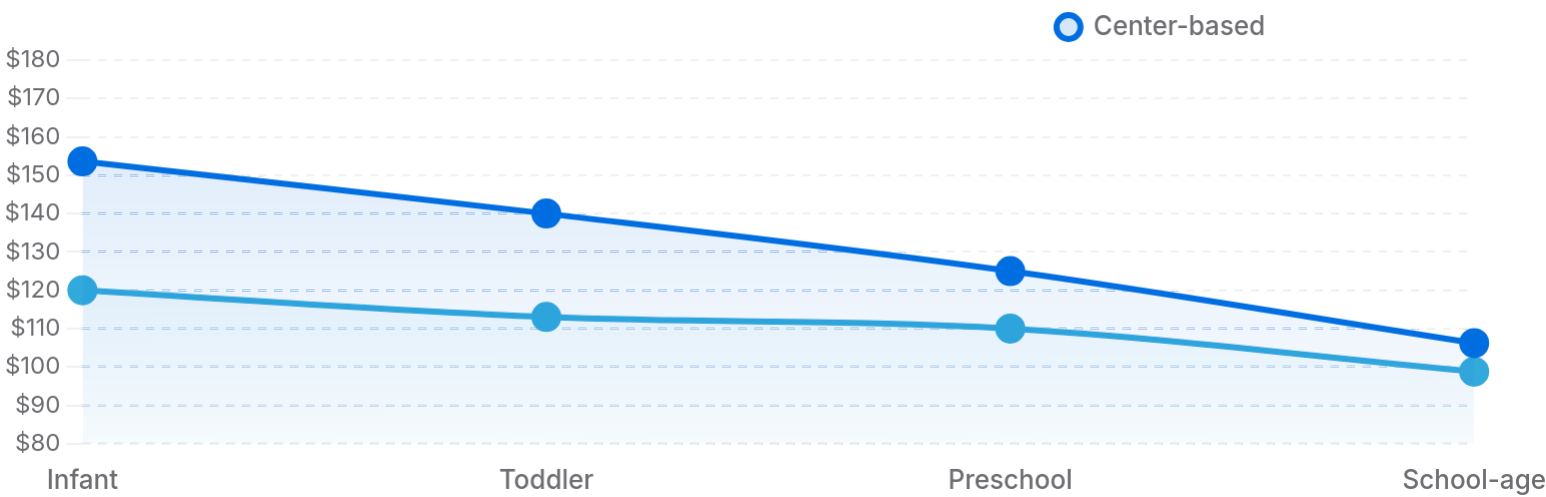
Weekly full-time childcare prices are highest for infants and toddlers, typically higher in centers than family childcare, and vary significantly across counties.

Source: U.S. Department of Labor Women's Bureau — National Database of Childcare Prices, 2018 county-level estimates.

SECTION 1 · AGE PATH

Weekly prices are highest at the beginning

Across 2018 county estimates, the median weekly price for center-based care drops from **\$153.60** for infants to **\$106.22** for school-age children. Family childcare follows the same pattern, falling from **\$120.00** to **\$98.77**.

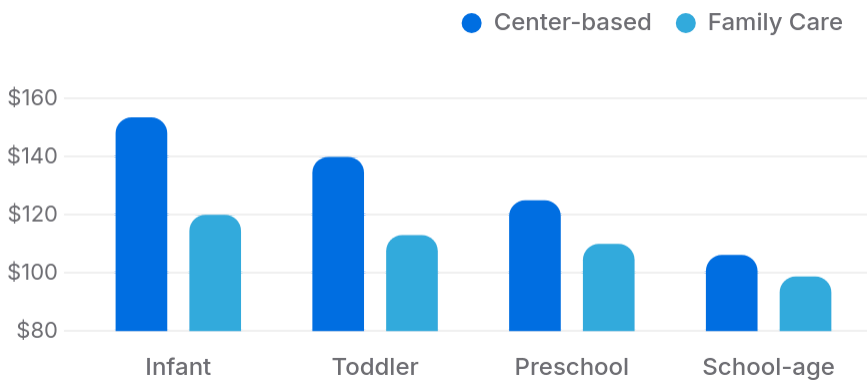


Key insight: Center-based infant care is about **31% higher** than center-based school-age care — the early years carry the steepest price tag.

SECTION 2 · PROVIDER TYPE

Center-based care usually costs more

At every age group, center-based care exceeds family childcare. The gap is widest for infants.

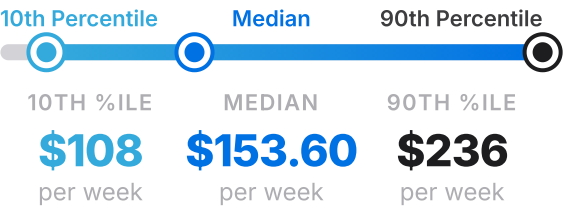


Infant	+\$33.60 / wk	Toddler	+\$26.96 / wk
Preschool	+\$15.00 / wk	School-age	+\$7.45 / wk

SECTION 3 · GEOGRAPHY

Where you live changes what families pay

For center-based infant care in 2018, county-level prices ranged dramatically from the 10th to the 90th percentile.

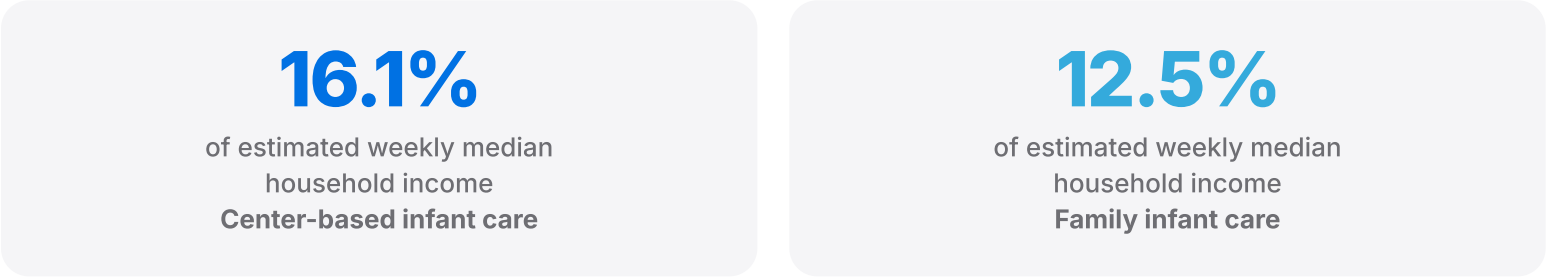


\$128/week spread between the lowest and highest county bands — childcare cost is a **location issue**, not just a family budgeting issue.

SECTION 4 · BUDGET BURDEN

Why this matters for working parents

Using county median household income as a rough local context measure, infant childcare in 2018 consumed a significant share of estimated weekly household income at the median county.



Note: These figures use county-level median household income only as rough local context — not a direct household affordability measure. The dataset does not include household-level income data.

What this data does not show

These data show prices, not whether childcare slots are available. They also do not include informal care from relatives or friends, and some values were standardized or imputed during dataset construction.

Use local numbers to advocate

Plan ahead for the early-years cost spike. Use local childcare price data when asking employers about flexible schedules, dependent-care support, or other family benefits. Share the numbers with local leaders when childcare costs create barriers to work.